



“If the stars should appear one night in a thousand years, how would men believe and adore; and preserve for many generations the remembrance of the city of God which had been shown! But every night come out these envoys of beauty, and light the universe with their admonishing smile.”

Ralph Waldo Emerson

AS THE EARTH MAKES its year-long journey around the Sun, the night sky changes its appearance and the stars seem to move from east to west. Depending on the observer's location, some stars are circumpolar and always visible, but others are seen only at certain times of the year. For example, some stars are seen well in the evening sky in January, but are invisible 6 months later, when the Earth has moved around its orbit to the opposite side of the Sun. The following section tracks seasonal changes in the night sky for observers in both the Northern and Southern Hemispheres. As well as covering the regular annual cycles of the stars and constellations, it charts the positions of the planets and provides an observer's guide to celestial events, such as meteor showers and eclipses of the Sun and Moon.

THE PERSEID METEORS

This composite image shows the Perseid meteor shower that occurs in August every year. Also visible is the star-studded band of the Milky Way.

MONTHLY SKY GUIDE